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English 178x: The American Novel
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A Tale of Two Manipulations:
How Humbert Humbert tricked the whole world into reading his story

Vladimir Nabokov's *Lolita* is an intense piece of manipulation, and Humbert Humbert is the mastermind. Published in 1955, Lolita is about Humbert Humbert, a middle-aged man who marries a widow because he is infatuated by her 12-year-old daughter, who he later kidnaps and sexually abuses. It is a story about the emotional and physical manipulation that occurs on the accounts of many parties. This central topic of pedophilia is what makes the novel so surprising. Pedophilia is not widely talked about in modern American society, shunned away due to the utter physical and moral horrors associated with the actions involved and those who partake are, perhaps rightfully, frequently deemed unworthy of attention. However, *Lolita,* although being quite controversial, is not only recognized as an acceptable work of writing but is even revered by many. How can a book like this become so widely read and receive such critical acclaim? Because this is not simply a novel about pedophilia, but rather about a larger idea – how society interacts with such taboo topics. This leads us to the second, and arguably more important, form of manipulation in the book, hidden within the relationship that narrator Humbert Humbert cultivates with the reader. Through his presence as an unreliable narrator and his ability to control the descriptions associated with other forms of manipulation, Humbert Humbert pulls readers in to both the story and to his point of view. This distracts readers away from the immorality of the actions described and even creates room for empathy toward a character that in other settings would have been immediately dismissed, ultimately showing the power of storytelling style in shaping perspectives.

From the beginning, Humbert Humbert employs an exquisite-crafted storytelling style to subtly engage with readers in a way that makes them want to be sympathetic to him, serving as the foundation for further manipulation. The opening line, "Lolita, light of my life, fire of my loins. My sin, my soul," starts off a deep relationship with alliteration and word play that

Humbert will employ throughout the book (Nabokov 1). These lighthearted, witty word choices make the book seem more lyrical and seem more enticing to read. As if the prose were written as a poem, readers want to follow along, not only for the plot but equally for the aesthetic qualities of the writing, hoping to stumble upon and admire each instance of alliteration or word play scattered throughout. This is a testament to Humbert's, or in reality Nabokov's, exceptional control over writing, making each sentence into a story in such a way that satisfies a reader's desire for text that is at once pretty, immersive, clever and leaves them turning pages to find more. What is most striking about this flowery writing style however is the content to which it is applied. By employing this rich and elegant writing to a topic of such a contrasting crude nature, Humbert invites his readers to pay close attention to all of the vivid details layered within his writing to the point of encouraging them to treat the actual content as a secondary matter. Perhaps this is necessary as without such beautiful writing readers might not have opened the book or felt too horrified by the material to read beyond the first few pages. The conscious choice to approach pedophilia through the however-twisted lens of the abuser, where the situation is seen as inspiring beauty, turns most readers' preconceived notions on the head, and forces them to at least engage with the content for a little to dive deeper into the prose before casting judgment. Furthermore, this might even distract from the larger issues being described in the book, consuming the reader's attention so that they do not think too critically about the other actions.

In other instances, Humbert manipulates the conventional writing styles and creates unique syntactical choices for added impact to elicit emotions more sharply within the readers. The best example of this is early on in the book, when he is explaining his family background and childhood. When describing his mother's death, he says that she "died in a freak accident

(picnic, lightning) when [he] was three" (Nabokov 11). Through this parenthetical addition of information, a reader is initially confused on why these two words must be included. However, after puzzling over them for a few moments and realizing the true meaning behind the words – the fact that the mother was struck by lightning on a picnic – the reader realizes for themselves the true horrors that Humbert experienced so early on in his life. This is more effective in building a relationship with the reader than if Humbert had instead just spelt out the situation. By causing the reader to piece the puzzle together themselves, they are more invested in the story being told and thus in the characters involved. This leads to them feeling Humbert's pain more intensely. Putting these two together, the reader is further drawn into the book, both for the sense of challenge they feel to discover the next puzzle and for the sake of learning more about Humbert who they now have a deeper emotion connection to. The reader finds delight in seeing through this semi-translucent mystery: just like Humbert is enchanted by Lolita to the point that his judgment is clouded, the reader is enchanted by the novel's prose, clouding their judgment as well. Through this, the reader becomes complicit in the actions of the book, as they are intrigued by finding the next hidden pun or crafty use of syntax, and through this process allow Humbert's otherwise unapproachable story to be told.

With this established rapport and through the flowery language, Humbert never tries to hide the deep sexual desires he feels toward Lolita, no matter how taboo or unacceptable they might be. In fact, he talks about these desires in great detail, so much that it is enough to make most readers uncomfortable. But while he does this, it is important to note that he especially likes to use imagery that invokes scenes from nature to talk about Lolita. For example, he mentions how he "squeezed that little hot paw" and describes how much he wants to kiss her " cate-boned, long-toed, monkeyish feet" (Nabokov 49). Here, he is fixating on some of her specific physical

qualities and describing them as parallel to the physical traits of other animals like cats or monkeys. This forces the reader to focus on Lolita's presence as simply an animal that is part of the natural world, rather than as a sentient being who can be impacted by the actions and thoughts of others. By drawing upon these nature-based themes, he is emphasizing the physiological side to his desires and actions, and thus taking the focus away from other interpretations of his actions, such as where they could indicate a significant lapse in judgement as having sex with minors is an offense. Instead, through this natural imagery, he is portraying Lolita as an animal that is causing a natural reaction within his body's innate desires, something that is part of his chemical and physical makeup as a human being and thus something that he cannot control. Through the shift in perspective that these literary choices encourage, Humbert is subtlety portraying himself as a victim – a victim of his own bodily desires – rather than as a rational thinking being who had full agency when choosing to sexually abuse a young girl. Another possible interpretation of this is that the immense level of detail itself, where Humbert Humbert fixates her attention so thoroughly on Lolita and repeatedly describes shifts in her posture or clothing at such a miniscule level, contributes to a sensation that our narrator is not completely mentally stable. This use of text to simulate the potential obsessive and neurotic tendencies of the narrator may again help to shift the focus of the story from the wrongs that Humbert committed to the circumstances that caused this to happen, underscoring his position as a victim. Thus, the style of storytelling once again shifts the narrative being conveyed, as readers become more likely to sympathize with than shun Humbert Humbert.

Beyond the animal-based imagery, Humbert Humbert sometimes takes a more direct approach to emphasize his perception that the events of the novel were out of his control. One method that he does to achieve this is the constant use and repetition of the word nymphet. This

is the diminutive form of the word nymph, which is a term used in Greek mythology to describe a female deity who embodies both nature and feminine ideals and is seen as pure and attractive to men. By repeatedly using a term that is so tied to Greek mythology to describe Lolita, Humbert is drawing connections between the elusive, mysterious powers of deities and the way that he perceives Lolita. Thus, Lolita's physical attractiveness is being portrayed as not just a quality that was decided upon by Humbert Humbert himself but rather something inherent to her almost god-like nature, so Humbert Humbert should not be punished for having simply been in her presence and fallen under her spell. This emphasis on seeing Lolita as a god-like figure paints her beauty as a universal standard, which implies that all men might fall victim to her beauty if they are in her presence. This subtly redistributes the blame away from Humbert and instead toward Lolita's irresistibility. Through this simple word choice, Humbert significantly shifts a reader's perception of him and the reception to his story.

Still, Humbert Humbert is careful not to portray himself as a victim all the time. In fact, he skillfully anticipates a reader's likely reactions to his actions and finds ways to address them in his storytelling in order to strengthen his connection to the reader and win their loyalty. In many instances, he even sometimes seems to use his own negative perceptions of his horrible actions to earn greater sympathy from the reader. For example, he says, "But never mind, never mind, I am only a brute, never mind, let us go on with my miserable story" after talking about how much he wanted to caress Lolita even while asks to be left alone (Nabokov 176). While reading the passages, readers are likely considering the immorality of the situation and are looking at Humbert in shock or disgust. Anticipating the reader's reaction to such an overt statement of wanting to sexually abuse his stepdaughter, he calls himself out for his actions by saying that he is a "brute." Through this, a reader feels that their opinions regarding the situation

are recognized by and even shared with Humbert Humbert, which increases his credibility as a narrator in their eyes, even though he was actually the person doing the questionable actions in the passage and thus should objectively been seen with less respect. Moments like this make his story, grounded in the foundation that he was actually a victim or at least not fully responsible for his choices regarding sexual abuse, more widely believed by readers because of this increased credibility due to shared disdain for his actions.

With this in mind, we can explore the larger implications that this idea of manipulating the narrative has on stories in our modern world. Humbert Humbert's expert manipulation of the narrative, drawing the reader into his perspective in a way that invites sympathy if not empathy, is a clear example in how the way in which stories are told can impact their reception. At the end of the novel, Humbert insists that this novel *Lolita* "be published only when Lolita is no longer alive" (Nabokov 281). This is his final push to control the narrative. By having the story be told from his point of view, Humbert Humbert's inner thoughts and observations have been explained in great detail and have been the fabric through which the story is told. The narrator is not omniscient, so we never truly see anyone else's perspective, such as Lolita's. Instead, as readers, we only see Humbert Humbert's perception of the other character's thoughts and emotions. Now, as the book would be published after Lolita's death, she not only does not get a chance to have her own thoughts and opinions showcased as she wishes in the book itself, but she also will not have the opportunity to refute any of the claims made about her in the novel. Thus, this wish about the publication date of the novel is Humbert Humbert's final way of maintaining his control over both the girl and the narrative. The very last words of the book in fact are "this is the only immortality you and I may share, my Lolita" (Nabokov 281). Through these words, a

double meaning exists. Lolita is at once both the object of Humbert Humbert's fascination and also the title of the book, driving home Humbert Humbert's desire to manipulate both of them.

Looking at a larger picture of how we interpret real life events, we can use the way Humbert Humbert's narration shapes how readers interact with the plot points to understand how we consume other media. Lolita's side of the story is never truly told; Humbert controls our perception of it by using word choice to both implicitly and explicitly define her motivations. Thus, in true sexual abuse stories, how is our perception of the events influenced by their narration as well as who is given the power to speak? We must remain wary of how just like in *Lolita*, flowery speech can be used to distract us and various imagery can be used to cloud our judgment. Those with their reputation or criminal records at stake are motivated to be unreliable narrators and we must be careful not to be complicit in letting only one side of the story be fully shared and engaged with.

Perhaps Humbert put it best himself: "Oh, my Lolita, I have only words to play with!" (Nabokov 32). This ties together the fundamental aspects of his manipulation of the reader, showing how his use of word play and words that evoke specific emotions in the reader provides the world with a skewed perception of the situation, allowing him to assert control over both the narrative and his readers.

Dear Rhea,

This is a very accomplished paper. Your argument is compelling; you move through its various steps with a logical flow, and the whole thing has a sound structure. You exemplify great skill for close reading in your paragraphs on the animal and nature imagery used to describe Dolly/Lolita, and on the Greek mythology associations with the term "nymphet." You use the conclusion of your paper to open out onto a broader significance and relate our specific reading of Lolita to situations with higher stakes and more urgency. Very thoughtful and thought-provoking work.

Grade: A